PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #4 · TRUSTING OTHERS · HIDDEN INTENTIONS

"People always try to hide what they are doing"

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Do you often suspect that people are hiding their real intentions or planning something they will not tell you about? Does this leave you constantly on guard, looking for clues for their true intentions? The information below can help you separate what you know from what you fear, ask clear questions, and find peace in God's care while allowing trust to grow through honest relationships.

Where it often comes from

Believing that you have been deceived, betrayed, or surprised by someone's harmful actions can teach you to expect that they are communicating hidden plans or meanings. Family secrecy, unpredictable behavior, or repeated warnings about other people can strengthen the belief that you must always search beneath the surface to find people's true meanings or intentions. Even ordinary privacy or an incomplete explanation may then feel like evidence of deception--even without a solid basis for this belief.

How the belief can keep itself going

Expecting concealed intentions can lead to checking, repeatedly questioning people, or replaying conversations for clues. Checking may briefly ease anxiety, but it can make uncertainty feel harder to tolerate. Another person's discomfort with repeated questioning may then seem to confirm the original suspicion. Pausing, asking one respectful question, and comparing predictions with observable behavior can interrupt this cycle.

What Scripture teaches

God invites us to bring our worries to Him and receive His peace. We are not required to uncover every private thought or predict every action. Love makes room for patience and hope, and faithful friendship can grow through experience. Trusting God helps us respond to what is actually happening instead of treating every unanswered question as proof of deception.

> *"When I am afraid, I put my trust in You." (Psalm 56:3)*

Also see

> "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You." (Isaiah 26:3)

> "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you." (1 Peter 5:7)

> "A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity." (Proverbs 17:17)

> "It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things." (1 Corinthians 13:7)

Common self-statements

- They are keeping something from me.
- If I stop watching, they will catch me off guard.
- There must be another reason they are doing this.
- I need to work out what they are really planning.
- A vague answer means they are deceiving me.
- I cannot relax until I know their true intentions.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know an intention that has not been stated.
- Overgeneralization: Turning past deception into an expectation about everyone.
- Jumping to conclusions: Treating incomplete information as proof of a hidden plan.
- Confirmation bias: Looking for clues that support suspicion while dismissing openness.
- Catastrophizing: Predicting harm whenever I do not know someone's plans.
- Emotional reasoning: Treating anxiety as evidence that deception is occurring.

Challenging questions

- What did I directly observe, and what intention am I guessing?
- Does missing information necessarily mean deliberate deception?
- Could privacy, distraction, uncertainty, or a change of plans explain this?
- What consistent actions support a more trusting interpretation?
- Can I ask one clear question without accusing or repeatedly checking?
- What would I do differently if I could tolerate not knowing everything?

Truth summary

I cannot know every thought or plan another person has. Uncertainty and ordinary privacy do not prove deception. I can ask clear questions, notice consistent actions, and allow reliable people to earn my trust. I can place my anxiety in God's care without constantly searching for hidden intentions.

A short prayer

Father, help me separate what I see from what I fear. Calm the urge to search for hidden motives. Give me patience to listen, courage to ask kindly, and peace to leave unanswered questions with You. Help me recognize and receive honest care. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Wisdom
- Truth

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Communication
- Judgmental
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Whom Shall I Fear (God of Angel Armies)
Chris Tomlin

Practice placing fear in God's care instead of feeling responsible for anticipating every threat.

Peace Be Still
Hope Darst

Reflect on receiving peace when uncertainty makes you anxious.

Just Be Held
Casting Crowns

Consider releasing the pressure to keep everything under your control.

Be Still
Hillsong Worship

Pause the search for hidden intentions and focus on God's faithful presence.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Generalized distrust can follow betrayal, trauma, or abuse and may occur with anxiety, depression, or other conditions; it is not specific to a personality disorder. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Distrust can be reasonable when someone is unsafe; experiments should be low-stakes, and anyone in an abusive or dangerous situation should seek safety and professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "Can I respond to today's facts with patience and trust, without trying to uncover every hidden thought?"

My Plan for Replacing "People always try to hide what they are doing"

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

"People always try to hide what they are doing" I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you suspect someone is hiding a plan.

- ☐ What did I directly observe, and what intention am I guessing?
- ☐ Does missing information necessarily mean deliberate deception?
- ☐ Could privacy, distraction, uncertainty, or a change of plans explain this?
- ☐ What consistent actions support a more trusting interpretation?
- ☐ Can I ask one clear question without accusing or repeatedly checking?
- ☐ What would I do differently if I could tolerate not knowing everything?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Not knowing everything does not prove that someone is deceiving me.
- ☐ A person can have privacy without intending harm.
- ☐ I can ask once, listen carefully, and return to my own activities.
- ☐ Consistent actions are better evidence than guesses about motives.
- ☐ I can tolerate some uncertainty and still make sensible choices.
- ☐ God cares for me; I do not need to monitor everyone's plans.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Psalm 56:3
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."
- ☐ Isaiah 26:3
  "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You."
- ☐ 1 Peter 5:7
  "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."
- ☐ Proverbs 17:17
  "A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity."

☐ 1 Corinthians 13:7
“It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.”

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

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5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Read your Truth Card three times daily and memorize your chosen verse. Set a phone or watch reminder, or place a note where you will see it. Listen to one song daily and record the truth you want to practice.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ In an ordinary interaction with a reliable person, write the observable facts separately from your guess about their intentions. List two other explanations.
- ☐ Ask one neutral question about a small uncertainty, such as “Could you explain the plan?” Listen without repeating the question for reassurance.
- ☐ When there is no concrete sign of danger, postpone an unnecessary check for 15 minutes. Rate your anxiety before and after, then return to an ordinary task.
- ☐ Agree on one small shared plan with a dependable friend. Compare what you predicted with what the person actually did.

Choose an ordinary, low-stakes situation. Do not use these exercises with someone who is threatening, coercive, or abusive, or to dismiss concrete evidence of deception.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
5			
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, record the song, the truth it reinforces, and one way to practice that truth today.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~People always try to hide what they are doing~~

NEW TRUTH:
Missing information is not proof of deception. I can ask clearly, judge actions fairly, and trust God with what I do not know.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Psalm 56:3

A short prayer

Lord, thank You that You are faithful. Help me notice trustworthy people, trust wisely, set healthy limits, and remember that I am safe in Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.